Ramanna, who is considered the father of India's nuclear programme, had been instrumental in setting up the facility at Pokhran, and in February of that year he is reported to have said, 'We are ready to tickle the dragon's tail'.[58] There could be no doubt as to who the 'dragon' was. After the successful explosion, a scientist at the site rang Prime Minister Indira Gandhi conveying a brief message, 'Madam, the Buddha has finally smiled'.[59] The test was set to coincide with the birthday of the Lord Buddha, and, thus, the operation had been codenamed the Smiling Buddha.[60]

India no longer had any reason to fear another Chinese attack and China's strategy after 1962 was, anyway, not to confront India directly. It would instead be a proxy war. The first anti-government force in India to receive support from China was the Naga rebel movement on the eastern border with Myanmar. Mowu Gwizan, a staunch Christian like most other Nagas, may have been surprised when, in June 1962, his Pakistani hosts in Karachi introduced him to a representative of Communist China promising support. There was a limit to how much aid and assistance Pakistan could provide to the Naga rebels without provoking a backlash from India. China had no such fears or qualms and even if the Nagas were Christians, they could prove to be a useful force in the efforts to destabilize India.

Back in the Naga Hills, Mowu discussed the offer with the other leaders of the Naga rebel army, and decided to take it up. Two men were selected to lead the first Naga trek to China, Thinoselie Medom Keyho, a veteran of the Naga struggle who had joined the Naga National Council (NNC) and its rebel army in the 1950s, and the much younger Thuingaleng Muivah, a Naga from Manipur who, despite his belief in Christianity, was inspired by Marxist ideology. In January 1967, after a four-month trek through northern Myanmar, they were well received at the Chinese border and, after some clarifications about their identity had been made, they were taken to the Chinese city of Tengchong in Yunnan. Thinoselie and Muivah were then flown to Beijing where they were lodged in the Beijing Hotel, while the 130 men who had followed them to China were stationed in a newly built training camp near Tengchong. In November 1967, Thinoselie and all the soldiers trekked back to India with new automatic rifles, machine guns, and rocket launchers. Muivah stayed behind in Beijing.[61]